

God Save the King vs The Star-Spangled Banner

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. Set-up (1-2 min)

Quick intro: before every World Cup match, both teams' anthems are played. Ask: *Do you know what the UK and US anthems actually say?* Most students will recognise the tunes but not the words – that's the hook.

2. A little history (3-4 min - read aloud or hand out)

God Save the King No one knows for certain who wrote it. It became popular in London theatres in 1745, sung as a patriotic song during a period of political unrest, and gradually became the UK's national anthem by tradition rather than official decree – Britain still has no law making it official. The words change between "King" and "Queen" depending on the monarch: it's been "God Save the King" since Charles III became king in 2022, after 70 years of "God Save the Queen" under Elizabeth II.

The Star-Spangled Banner Written as a poem in 1814 by Francis Scott Key, a lawyer watching the British bombard Fort McHenry, near Baltimore, during the War of 1812. Key was relieved to see, at dawn, that the American flag was still flying over the fort – that image is the heart of the song. The poem was set to an existing British tune and only became the official US national anthem in 1931, over a century later.

(Discussion prompt: one anthem is a prayer for a monarch, the other is a description of a single night during a war – ask students what that says about each country's relationship to its own history.)

3. The lyrics (first verse of each - what's actually sung at matches)

God Save the King

God save our gracious King, Long live our noble King, God save the King: Send him victorious, Happy and glorious, Long to reign over us, God save the King.

The Star-Spangled Banner

O say can you see, by the dawn's early light, What so proudly we hailed at the twilight's last gleaming? Whose broad stripes and bright stars, through the perilous fight, O'er the ramparts we watched, were so gallantly streaming? And the rockets' red glare, the bombs bursting in air, Gave proof through the night that our flag was still there. O say does that star-spangled banner yet wave O'er the land of the free and the home of the brave?

4. Vocabulary (differentiate by group)

A1-A2 - key words only

Word	Meaning
gracious	kind, generous (used of a king/queen)
reign	the period a king or queen rules
dawn	early morning, when the sun rises
gleaming	shining brightly
wave	move gently in the wind (flag)
brave	not afraid, courageous

B1-B2 - fuller glossary + discussion

Word/phrase	Meaning
victorious	having won
perilous	very dangerous
ramparts	defensive walls of a fort
gallantly	bravely, heroically
rockets' red glare	the bright light of exploding rockets (weapons)
star-spangled	covered/decorated with stars

Discussion: *Why might a flag still flying after a night of bombing be such a powerful image? What's the equivalent emotional core of "God Save the King" - what is it actually asking for?*

5. Comparison task (5-8 min)

In pairs, students fill in a short comparison grid (or discuss orally):

	God Save the King	Star-Spangled Banner
Who/what is it about?		
Is it calm or dramatic?		
One word to describe the mood		
What does it ask for / celebrate?		

Wrap-up question for the group: *If you had to write one line of a French anthem for this World Cup, what would it say?* (Light bridge to talking about "La Marseillaise" if you want to extend – also has a very different, revolutionary/battle tone worth contrasting.)

Note: both sets of lyrics are traditional/public domain texts, not modern copyrighted songs, so they're fine to print and hand out freely.

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About this activity

Standalone activity, ~15-20 min – pairs well with your pre-match anthem-ceremony listening activity